



INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 11

CULTURAL CHANGE IN INDIA

Cultural change in India can be analysed based on the following processes of

- Secularization
- Westernization
- Sanskritization
- Modernization.

SECULARAIZATION

1 Secularisation implies that what was previously regarded as religious is now ceasing to be such and it also implies a process of differentiation where various aspects of society - economic, political, religious, legal and moral become increasingly discrete in relation to each other.

2 The spread of the process of secularisation implies that various issues and events in personal and social life are evaluated not from the religious point of view, but from the utilitarian point of view.



ELEMENTS OF SECULARIZATION

- 1 **Decline of religiosity:**
 - In a perfectly secularized society religious considerations are replaced by rationalistic considerations.
- 2 **Rationality:** In this process of secularization two things occur:
 - Decline in religious control over individual and social behaviour.
 - Increase in rational attitude towards different events of individual and social life.
- 3 **Empiricism:** It includes three main areas:
 - Objective observation
 - Experimentation
 - Verification
- 4 **Process of differentiation:** Each aspect, i.e. economic, political, social, legal etc. has its own specialized functions.
- 5 **Scientific world view.**
- 6 **Social dynamism:** acceptance of new ideas and values.



PROCESS OF SECULARIZATION IN INDIA

- 1 After independence, India adopted a Constitution which guaranteed individual and collective freedom of religion.
- 2 It is also mentioned that no preference is given to any particular religion by the state. Rather each and every religion is to be treated equally.
- 3 By the Constitution two important instructions are given to the state:
 - a State must remain neutral to religious goals.
 - b It should not impose tax for religious purposes or encourage religious teachings in educational institutions financed by the state.

 The New York Times

A New Secularism Is Appearing in Islam

... Christianity, went through: secularization. Would Islam also lose its hegemony over public life, to become a mere one among various voices, ...

Dec 23, 2019



PROCESS OF SECULARIZATION IN INDIA

4 Secularization has two Constitutional principles:

- a** The principled interference in religious matters of any religious community.
- b** The principle of providing equal protection to all the religions.

5 Secularisation and modernisation can lead to revival of traditional forces because modern means of communication can accelerate communal forces. Thus emerge a difference between de-jure secularism envisaged in Constitution and de-facto secularism practiced by society.

IDEAS

Three Decades Ago, America Lost Its Religion. Why?

"Not religious" has become a specific American identity—one that distinguishes secular, liberal whites from the conservative, evangelical right.

PROCESS OF SECULARIZATION IN INDIA

6

West vs East:

- a** Hinduism and Buddhism unlike Christianity, have tolerated more primitive supernaturalism than eradicating them.
- b** Besides, the long-term historical process of secularisation and the extension of rational-principles to all areas of social life were less intense in non- Western countries like in Asia or the Middle East leading to a paradox of magical practice alongside sophisticated industrial techniques.



PROCESS OF SECULARIZATION IN INDIA

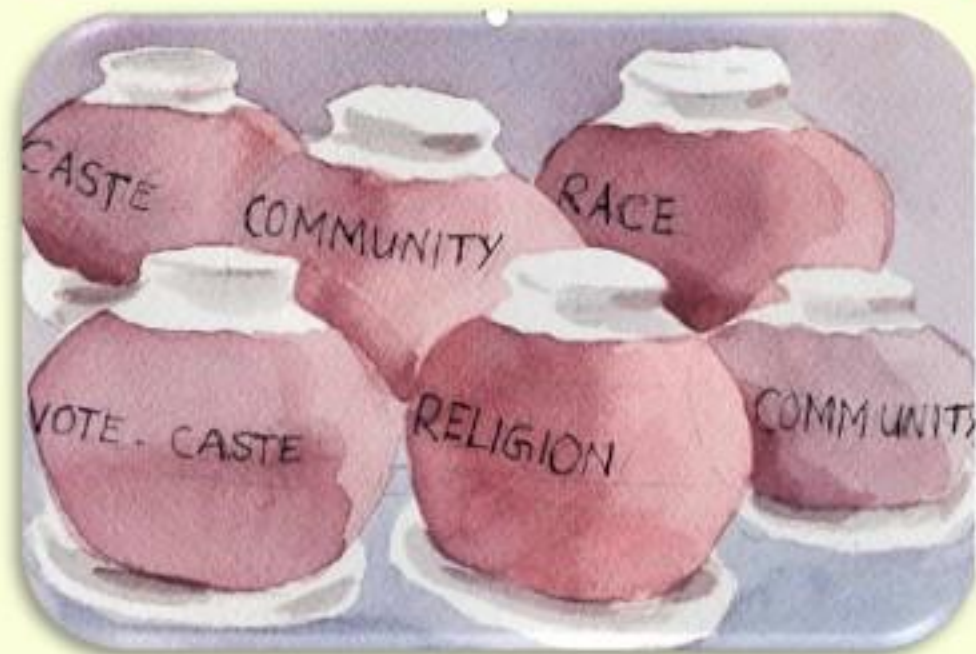
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Secularisation of caste

- a** In traditional India caste system operated within a religious framework. Belief systems of purity and pollution were central to its practice.
- b** Today it often functions as political pressure groups. Contemporary India has seen such formation of caste associations and caste based political parties.
- c** They seek to press upon the state their demands. Such a changed role of caste has been described as secularisation of caste.

8

On the whole, one can say that 'neither mass religiosity nor complete secularisation appear to be permanent historical possibilities'.



- 1 Westernization can be defined as “the changes brought about in Indian society and culture as a result of over 150 years of British rule, the term subsuming changes occurring at different levels viz. technology, institutions, ideology and values”.
- 2 Westernisation does involve the imitation of external forms of culture. It does not necessarily mean that people adopt modern values of democracy and equality. There were different kinds of westernisation.
- 3 One kind refers to the emergence of a westernised sub-cultural pattern through a minority section of Indians who first came in contact with Western culture.
- 4 Many of the early 19th century reformers were of this kind.
- 5 There has been also the general spread of Western cultural traits, such as the use of new technology, dress, food, and changes in the habits and styles of people in general.



6 Apart from ways of life and thinking the west influenced Indian art and literature.

7 Artists like Ravi Varma, Abanindranath Tagore, Chandu Menon and Bankimchandra Chattopadhyay were all grappling with the colonial encounter.

8 In the contemporary context often conflicts between generations are seen as cultural conflicts resulting from westernisation.

9 According to M.N. Srinivas, while 'lower castes' sought to be Sanskritised, 'upper castes' sought to be Westernized.



- 10** The British rule provided fresh avenues for social mobility altering the nature of pre-existing institutions such as schools and colleges which opened their doors to all castes and establishing new ones such as army, bureaucracy and law courts which recruited members on the basis of merit and hence provided ample source of mobility.
- 11** Westernization did not begin and end with British rule. It provided tracks which furthered and accelerated the mobility process which gained further momentum after Independence.
- 12** Independent India took rationalistic egalitarian and humanitarian principles from the British and created further room for mobility.

We are leaving our culture behind, for no reason 😞



13 But westernisation didn't completely replace sanskritisation.

- Printing Press used for printing Ramayan, Pandit using microphone is a ceremony
- Transportation system used to visit pilgrimages - strengthening religiosity.
- Within a university, Sanskrit department coexists with biotech department

SANSKRITISATION	WESTERNISATION
Sacred outlook	Secular outlook
Upward mobility by imitation	Upward mobility by development
Mobility within the framework of caste	Mobility outside framework of caste
Taboo on meat eating and consumption of alcohol	Promoted

Hence there is continuity of tradition and co-existence of modern elements.

1 From the 19th and more so the 20th century the term began to be associated with positive and desirable values.

2 In the early years, modernisation referred to improvement in technology and production processes. Increasingly, however, the term had a wider usage.

3 It involves both structural changes like urbanization, industrialisation and cultural changes like secularization, westernization.

4 However sometimes westernization is used interchangeably with modernisation.

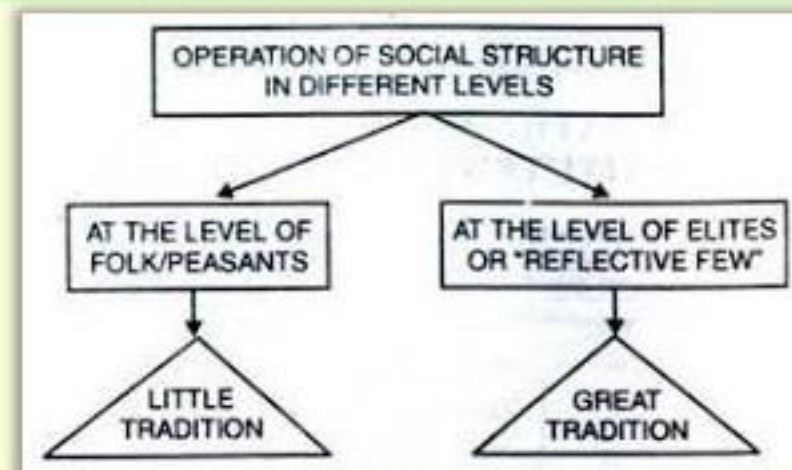
5 Modernization in India started mainly with the Western contact. Brought about many far reaching changes in culture & social structure of Indian society.



- 6 However, only after the establishment of British rule in India, modern cultural institutions and forms of social structure were introduced.
- 7 The Western tradition at the time of contact had itself undergone fundamental transformations through Industrial Revolution and social reformation. Its place was now being taken by rational individualism in economy and society.
- 8 With the exception of a handful of Orientalists who were overwhelmed by the textual grandeur of Indian tradition, majority were only impressed by contrasts which Indian society presented to their Western society.
- 9 The significance of British contribution to modernization mainly lies in the creation of such networks of social structure and culture which were modern and pan-Indian.



- 10** Initially, sub-culture or Little tradition of Westernization, small nucleus of interpreters, trader-cum-middlemen emerged who were slowly being socialized to Western ways.
- 11** Subsequently, there is emergence of sects which emphasized assimilation of Western cultural norms, e.g. Brahmosamaj, Prarthana Samaj - these ran a crusade against obscurantism Hindu traditions.
- 12** Its components were: a universalistic legal system, expansion of Western form of education, urbanization and industrialization, spread of new means of communication and transport and social reforms.
- 13** Along with these modernization norms, structural modernization also took place.
- 14** Growth of industrial entrepreneurship also contributed to the emergence of industrial working class and trade unions organized on corporate lines as in the West.

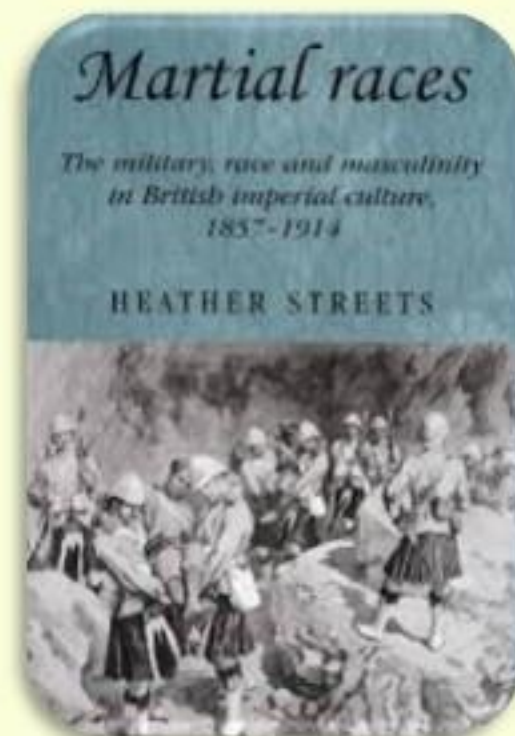


15 There was, however, one important feature of Indian modernization during the British period.

16 The growth of this process was selective and segmental. It was not integrated with the microstructures of Indian society, such as family, caste and village community.

17 For a long time, caste and ethnic factors were given recognition in recruitment of officers to army and middle and lower ranks of bureaucracy.

18 Later, in the twentieth century, as the nationalist movement gathered momentum, a communal electorate system was introduced.



19 These historical factors have deeply influenced the process of modernization followed during postcolonial period.

20 It increased contingency of traditional institutions to Indian process of modernisation.

21 Freedom movement ushered in a new political culture of modernization. At its centre was the personality of Mahatma Gandhi whose one foot was always deeply embedded in tradition.

22 Gandhi though a traditionalist in many ways, chose Nehru as his successor, who had a modernistic view of development. Thus, India's modernity is based on contradictory platforms.



MODERNISATION IN POST-INDEPENDENCE INDIA

- 1 Following Independence, modernization process in India has undergone a basic change from its colonial pattern.
- 2 Introduction of adult suffrage & a federal parliamentary form of political structure have carried politicization to every sector of social organization.
- 3 Conscious legal reforms in Hindu marriage & inheritance laws have deeply affected foundations of traditional Hindu family structure.
- 4 Community Development Projects, panchayats etc. have carried the cultural norms and role-strictures of modernity to each and every village in India.
- 5 Caste has in the process undergone radical transformation of roles, developed new functional adaptations and activated aspirations unleashed by democratization of polity and power structure.



MODERNISATION IN POST-INDEPENDENCE INDIA

6 As the process of modernization becomes all encompassing, it also generates inter-structural tensions and conflicts between traditions (past and contemporary).

7 Modernization, in its initial stages in India, did not lead to any serious breakdown because of the peculiar structural characteristics of the Indian society. Here, cultural system was fairly independent of political system.

8 According to Louis Dumont: "This domain (polity or artha) is relatively autonomous to absolute values".

9 There was also independence between the political system and the system of caste stratification.



10 Castes had their own panchayats and plural traditions, and similarly there also existed autonomy for groups and regional committees.

11 Modernity, mainly developed as a sub-structure and subculture without pervasive expansion in all sectors of life.

12 The cultural pre-requisites of a comprehensive modernization necessitate adaptive changes in the system of values.

13 For instance, secularism, untouchability, non-parochialism are cultural demands of modernization in contemporary India which its traditional value system continues to resist.

14 In cultural sphere, major changes have been introduced by legislations.



MODERNISATION IN POST-INDEPENDENCE INDIA

15 These seek to abolish social inequalities and exploitations handed down by tradition and accord democratic rights and constitutional privileges to all members of society. This has led to a trend away from Sanskritization.

16 However, the tradition also gets reinforcement in the process.

17 Modern media of communication and transport are increasingly used for spreading ritual order and for rational organization of religious groups and their mode of activities and social participation.

18 Inconsistencies are similarly there in structural changes that India has undergone during the postcolonial phase of modernization.

19 Micro-structures like caste, family and village community have retained their traditional character



- 20 Caste has shown unexpected elasticity and latent potential for adaptation with modern institutions, such as democratic participation.
- 21 These contradictions are, however, further magnified at the level of macro- structures, such as the political system, bureaucracy, elite structure, industry and economy.
- 22 The colonial period of modernization had homogeneity in elite structure. These elite from industrial, civil and military bureaucracies, as well as political spheres came from similar class-caste stratum; they had equitable exposure to Western education, and socialization.



23 Thus, major potential sources of breakdown in the Indian process of modernization may, in one form or another, be attributed to structural inconsistencies, such as:

- | | |
|--|--|
| a Democratization without spread of civic culture (education) | d Verbalization of a welfare ideology without its diffusion in social structure and its implementation as a social policy |
| b Bureaucratization without commitment to universalistic norms | e over-urbanization without industrialization |
| c Rise in media participation (communication) and aspiration without proportionate increase in resources and distributive justice | f Finally modernization without meaningful changes in the stratification system |

Caste, which represents institutionalized form of inequality sanctioned by tradition now fights battles against inequality and inegalitarianism with its own rational self-transformation into associations.

MODERNITY: DISENCHANTMENT AND ITS CHALLENGES IN INDIA

1 With the widening of modernization & globalization, there has grown disenchantment against modernization too.

2 Many of expectations of modernity remain unfulfilled. Challenges from the grass roots create bottlenecks for the processes of modernity.

3 On one hand, people feel that the age-old traditions have become irrelevant to fulfil their needs and on the other, they are dissatisfied with the processes of modernization. This is precisely the situation of disenchantment.

4 The increasing pace of modernization has given rise to a new kind of social movements such as environmental movements, gender movements and human rights movements



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suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

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0866 244 44 72

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